

That same winter, the Red Army defeated the Nazis at Stalingrad. The Soviets encircled the Germans, forcing a surrender in February 1943.

The turn of the tide

In a conference at Tehran in November 1943, the Allied leaders agreed on a strategy to liberate Europe. While the Russians drove the Germans back in the east, and the British and Americans advanced slowly through Italy, a huge Allied invasion force arrived in Normandy in June 1944. Eleven months later, it had reached the Elbe River in northern Germany, while Russian troops were advancing block by block through Berlin. Germany was being hit repeatedly by British Lancaster bomber aircraft from Bomber Command and the US Eighth Air Force. Staring at defeat, Hitler committed suicide on April 30, and Germany surrendered unconditionally a week later.

The last act of the war came in August 1945, when the US, after fighting island by island through the Pacific, put an end to Japanese resistance by dropping atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. The effects of the bombs were cataclysmic, inflicting unprecedented horror on the two Japanese cities.

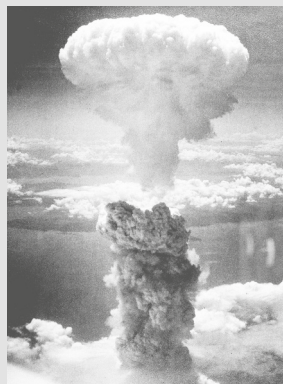
Nations united

Hitler's invasion of Poland marked the start of World War II, the largest and most destructive war in history, by the end of which an estimated 60 million people had been killed. Like their predecessors in 1918, the Allies were determined that this should be the last war of its kind.

Representatives of 50 nations met in 1945 to set up the United Nations. There was hope that this would mark the start of a new era of international understanding. ■



The Battle of Iwo Jima saw US troops fight against Japan's Imperial Army for possession of the tiny island in the Pacific Ocean, resulting in 100,000 Japanese casualties.



Hiroshima and Nagasaki

American planes dropped atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki to force Japan to surrender and end World War II. On August 6, 1945, "Little Boy" was dropped on Hiroshima. The inhabitants below had no idea what was about to happen. People, animals, and buildings were incinerated in the searing heat. Some 70,000 died immediately. Despite this terrible event, Japan did not surrender.

Japan had cause to reconsider its position when the Soviets entered the war against them by crossing into Manchuria on August 9. When, that same afternoon, the US dropped "Fat Man" on Nagasaki, instantly killing 50,000, Japan was brought to its knees and agreed to the Allies' terms of surrender. These unprecedented attacks avoided a bloody ground assault by the Allies on the Japanese mainland, but many thousands lost their lives as a result of the long-term effects of radiation sickness.